



This doesn't mean that camcorders have stagnated in terms of technology. Quite the contrary, better lenses, improved sensors and lighting and better storage mediums mean that camcorders today, are better than their predecessors. Another trend is the shrinking size – everyone wants something really tiny. Technology advancements means even a 1080i resolution camcorder can be quite compact. Only the 1080p camcorders are larger and these are not generally considered consumer-grade, rather they're meant for professionals.

Even if you're a very basic user, you should, at the very least, consider buying an HD camcorder. The higher resolution equates to better image quality and the other parts of HD camcorders are also suitably well built. Prices of HD 1080i camcorders typically start around the Rs. 36,000 mark, so they're not cheap by any means. Sadly build quality is one area where none of today's consumer-grade camcorders excel. It's almost like they're built on the lines of planned obsolescence, that is, they've got a definite usage life – and it's not a lot of time.

Sony's XR100E leads my recommendations for a good HD camcorder. Remember, since HD resolutions mean a lot more data, traditional media like DV tapes and DVDs do not cut it, therefore all HD camcorders will feature either flash or HDD storage. I prefer the latter, there's no issue of erase cycles and you get more space for less. The XR100E is priced at Rs. 39,990 and ships with an 80 GB hard drive – sufficient for nearly everyone. The camcorder is very compact in-hand and the on screen controls rather usable. The viewfinder is not the best around and should have been a little